Task Delegation Decision Guide

AI Literacy for the Modern Workforce

Use this guide before delegating a task to AI. Walk through four questions in sequence. Each question either routes you to a recommendation or advances you to the next filter.

Q1

STAKES

What happens if this output is wrong?

CONSIDER: *Who sees this? What decisions depend on it? What's the cost of an error: rework, reputational damage, legal exposure, financial loss?*

MINIMAL CONSEQUENCE	MODERATE TO SIGNIFICANT
FULLY DELEGABLE	Continue to **Q2** ↓

Q2

CONTEXTUAL KNOWLEDGE

Does this task require knowledge the model doesn't have?

CONSIDER: *Does it depend on unrecorded conversations, relationship context, proprietary data you haven't provided in the prompt, or real-time information the model can't access?*

YES	NO
HUMAN-ONLY	Continue to **Q3** ↓

Q3

VERIFIABILITY

Can you verify every key claim in the output against an independent source?

CONSIDER: *Is there a dashboard, database, document, or known standard you can check against? Or would you be relying on the output's plausibility alone? And does the check scale: can you verify a hundred outputs as cheaply as one, or does each one need a person? Anthropic engineers put it as: delegate where validation effort is small compared with creation effort.*

NO	YES
HUMAN-ONLY	Continue to **Q4** ↓

Q4

DOMAIN EXPERTISE

Do you have the expertise to catch errors in this output?

CONSIDER: *Would you recognize a wrong number, a flawed argument, or a misapplied concept in this domain? Or would a plausible-sounding error pass your review?*

NO	YES
HUMAN-ONLY	**AI-ASSISTED WITH REVIEW**

Note: If Q4 = No but the task still benefits from AI acceleration, use AI-assisted with mandatory peer review from someone with the domain expertise. This is the filter people skip most. In a survey of 319 knowledge workers, 58 said they lacked the domain knowledge to judge an AI response, and low confidence in one's own ability led to accepting outputs by default (Lee et al., CHI 2025, p. 11). Anthropic's engineers split the difference: some use AI only where they can verify it, and those working outside their expertise change how they prompt, asking the model for options to research rather than answers to accept (Huang et al., Dec 2025).

RECOMMENDATION REFERENCE

FULLY DELEGABLE

WHAT IT MEANS

AI produces the output from a clear task definition; you spot-check the result.

TYPICAL TASKS

Data compilation from known sources, formatting, proofreading, standard translations, template population.

AI-ASSISTED WITH REVIEW

WHAT IT MEANS

AI produces a draft or structure; you direct, evaluate, and revise using your expertise.

TYPICAL TASKS

Comparative analysis with verified inputs, first-draft summaries you'll review, structural scaffolding.

HUMAN-ONLY

WHAT IT MEANS

You produce the output. AI may assist with sub-components, but the core judgment stays with you.

TYPICAL TASKS

Strategic recommendations, causal interpretation, tasks depending on unrecorded or proprietary information.

ONE TASK, MULTIPLE COMPONENTS

Most workplace tasks are bundles of sub-tasks with different risk profiles. Apply this guide *per component*, not per deliverable. A quarterly business review might include data compilation (fully delegable), trend narrative (AI-assisted), and strategic recommendations (human-only). The framework names this split directly: deconstructing a task into AI, human, and collaborative components (Dakan & Feller, 2025, p. 4).

When you decompose a task into separate components, a compilation step followed by a dedicated human verification step can be fully delegated even when the overall deliverable carries significant stakes, because the verification step absorbs the risk. If compilation and verification are not separated, the combined task routes through the full flowchart at the higher stakes level.

These four questions are not only a training scaffold. When Anthropic interviewed 53 of its own engineers about what they hand to Claude, the same tests came back: tasks where checking the output costs less than producing it, self-contained components, work where quality is not critical, and tasks the engineer knows well enough to catch errors. Tasks that need context the model lacks, or strategic and design judgment, stayed human. Even these heavy users said they could fully delegate only a fifth of their work or less. Source: Huang et al., Dec 2025 (Anthropic engineers; findings may not generalize).

BEFORE THE FOUR QUESTIONS: THE DATA GATE

The flowchart assumes the task is yours to delegate. One gate comes first: whatever you paste into an AI tool leaves your organization's boundary the moment you send it. MIT's 2026 review of its own AI platforms found that most commercial plans let users disable training capture. The default, however, is often to record sessions (MIT Ad Hoc Committee, 2026, p. 25). Client records, unreleased financials, personal data, internal strategy, anything under NDA — whether that material can enter an external tool at all is an organizational policy decision, not an individual delegation decision. The framework treats this as part of Delegation: evaluating a tool against operational and regulatory needs is a Platform Awareness skill (Dakan & Feller, 2025, p. 4).

Check your organization's AI-use policy before the flowchart, not after. If no policy exists, that absence is worth surfacing — R7's Delegation Norms section is the conversation starter for exactly this question.

Framework: 4D AI Fluency Framework, Delegation competency (Dakan & Feller, 2025, pp. 3–4), as taught in Anthropic's AI Fluency course.

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